The Dust Bowl: Study Packet

Mr. Reyes’s U.S. History · Unit 7 · fictional study packet. Be ready to explain causes, responses and results.

What it was

Dust Bowl: a period in the 1930s when severe drought and wind erosion turned farmland on the Southern Great Plains (parts of Oklahoma, Texas, Kansas, Colorado and New Mexico) into dust storms.

Causes

Great Plow-Up: during and after World War I, high wheat prices led farmers to plow up millions of acres of native prairie grass, whose deep roots had held the soil in place.

Drought: starting in 1931, years of far-below-average rainfall dried out the exposed soil, and strong winds lifted it into huge dust clouds.

Farming practices: farmers planted the same crop year after year and left fields bare after harvest, which left soil loose and easy to blow away.

Great Depression: crop prices collapsed, so many farmers could not pay loans and could not afford to change how they farmed.

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Responses

Soil Conservation Service: created in 1935 within the federal government to teach farmers methods that hold soil, such as contour plowing and crop rotation.

Shelterbelts: rows of trees planted across the Plains, starting in 1934, to slow the wind and protect fields.

Taylor Grazing Act: a 1934 law that regulated grazing on public land so grass could recover.

Black Sunday: on April 14, 1935, a huge dust storm swept the Plains and drew national attention to the crisis.

Results

Migration: hundreds of thousands of people left the Plains. Many families, nicknamed “Okies” even when they were not from Oklahoma, traveled to California looking for work.

Lasting farming changes: contour plowing, crop rotation and leaving crop residue on fields became common, and the federal government took a larger role in protecting farmland.

Cultural memory: John Steinbeck’s novel The Grapes of Wrath (1939) and the photographs of Dorothea Lange showed the human cost to the whole country.